THE LETTERS OF THE RAMBAM

Avraham Is Your Father: The Rambam's Letters to Ovadia the Convert

The Letters of the Rambam (2025)

Source: Igrot HaRambam: the three responsa to Ovadia the Righteous Convert (written in Hebrew)

Shiur: First class of the series on the Rambam's letters, given by Dayan Daniel Kada on Zoom, Tuesday 21 January 2025

These notes are based on the Sofer.ai transcript of the recording.

Introduction: Why Study the Rambam's Letters?

The Tuesday-night shiurim "over the past few years" have focused on the Rambam: **Hilchot Deot, Hilchot Teshuvah, Yesodei HaTorah, the 13 Principles, the Shemonah Perakim**. This new series, "a good part of the year, if not the whole year," is **his letters**.

The Rambam in brief

Life	Born **1138** in Spain; a few years in Morocco; most of his life in **Egypt**; died **1204**
Day job	Doctor; medical works and works on logic
Commentary on the Mishnah	His first work, written aged roughly 20–23
Mishneh Torah	14 books codifying the entire Torah and Talmud, "the only one to have done what he did, before or since"
Sefer HaMitzvot	Enumerating the 613 commandments
Moreh Nevuchim	His main philosophical work
Responsa and letters	

What the letters add

His books are **systematic**; we learn little of his personal life from them. The letters are freer and more personal. For example, everyone knows of his son **Rabbi Avraham**; only from the letters do we learn he also had **a daughter, who died**.

- Most letters were written in **Arabic** (the Rambam wrote that he expresses himself best in it), and we read them in Hebrew translation.
- The plan: shorter letters on specific topics first (**Ovadia, Astrology, Martyrdom**), later the big ones (**Resurrection, Yemen**).

Who Was Ovadia?

- A **convert from Islam**, living in **Jerusalem**.
- He wrote to the Rambam **in Hebrew**, probably to express himself in his new language and identity, and the Rambam replied **in Hebrew**. So we have the Rambam's own words.
- The letters are undated, but they reference the **Mishneh Torah**, completed in **1180**, so they fall between **1180 and 1204**.
- They were cited by the **Rashba** and the **Radbaz**, and taken on **as halacha**. The first one settled a long-running debate.

Letter	Topic
1	The **liturgy** a convert should use
2	**Free will**, even in marriage
3	Whether **Islam** is idolatry, and how Jews must treat a convert

The Rambam's tone throughout is striking: though there's no evidence Ovadia was a scholar, he calls him **"the wise, the understanding"** and praises and encourages him in all three letters. And he signs himself **משה בן מימון**, "of those exiled from Jerusalem," that is, living outside the Land.

Letter 1: "The God of *Our* Fathers"?

The question

Praying alone, or leading as **chazan**, should a convert say:

- **אלהינו ואלהי אבותינו**, "our God and God of our fathers" (the Amidah)
- **אשר קדשנו במצוותיו וציוונו**, "who sanctified us... and commanded us"
- **אשר בחר בנו מכל העמים**, "who chose us from all the nations" (the blessing before the Torah reading)
- **שהנחלת לאבותינו ארץ חמדה**, "who gave our fathers a desirable land" (Birkat HaMazon)
- **שהוצאתנו מארץ מצרים**, "who took us out of Egypt"; **שעשה ניסים לאבותינו**, "who did miracles for our fathers"

How can I say these? I chose voluntarily; Hashem didn't "command" me. Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov aren't my biological ancestors.

The answer: say everything

"You should pray **as every other Jew prays**, whether alone or as chazan."

Avraham is the father of all who follow him. He was the first to teach the unity of God; thousands came under his and Sarah's wings ("Avraham looked after the men and Sarah the women"). Hashem commanded him: **למען אשר יצוה את בניו ואת ביתו אחריו ושמרו דרך ה'**, "teach your children and household after you." So his legacy endures:

Everyone who converts, to the end of time, is **a student of Avraham**, of his household. Avraham is the ancestor of his **biological** descendants and the **spiritual** ancestor of all who practise what he preached.

So *"God of our fathers"* is true, and so is *"the land You gave our fathers"*, since the covenant of the land was made with Avraham.

What about "who took us out of Egypt"? Spiritual ancestry doesn't stretch that far. "If you want," you may change the wording; **but it's totally fine** to say what everyone says:

"Once you come under the wings of Hashem, **you are part of us**. Everyone else says it; you say it with them."

The Rambam is **unequivocal**: **there is no difference between us and you.** Don't say *"who chose Israel"* and the like; say **"who chose *us*... gave *us* the Torah."** As the Torah says, **חוקה אחת לכם ולגר, תורה אחת ומשפט אחד יהיה לכם ולגר הגר אתכם**: one law for the native and the convert.

Our ancestors were idolaters too

"Our own biological ancestors" served idols in Egypt. The Midrash says the sea was reluctant to split, since **"these are idol worshippers and those are idol worshippers,"** until Moshe saved them. So why should you think less of yourself?

"We trace our lineage to Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov; you trace yours to Him who spoke and the world came to be."

As Yeshayahu says: **זה יאמר לה' אני, וזה יקרא בשם יעקב**: one says "I am Hashem's," another calls himself by the name of Yaakov.

Only then, the source

"How you cannot divorce a posek's outlook from the way he rules": the Rambam gives **his own reasoning first** and brings the source **at the end**.

- **Mishnah Bikkurim 1:4**: a convert **brings** bikkurim but **doesn't recite** the declaration, because he can't say "the land Hashem swore to our fathers"; and praying alone he says **"God of the fathers of Israel."**
- **The Yerushalmi**: **Rabbi Yehudah** disagrees: he does recite, because Avraham is called **אב המון גוים**, "father of a multitude of nations."
- **The Rambam rules like the Yerushalmi.**

That is rare. The Bavli is the authoritative Talmud, and this is an unattributed (*stam*) Mishnah, which carries great weight. The Rambam preferred the less authoritative Yerushalmi **because**

it fitted his logic: he didn't want the convert to be made to pray differently from everyone else. "Of course, if there were only the Mishnah, he'd have to accept it. But there were two sources."

On starting points, the Rabbi said: some poskim start from *forbidden until proven permitted*; others from *permitted until proven forbidden*. "What I received from my teachers: unless you have a source that something is forbidden, it's not forbidden."

The debate the Rambam settled

- **Rabbeinu Tam** (Rashi's grandson, France) **forbade** a convert to be chazan (he'd have to say *"God of our fathers"*) or to **lead zimmun**. The real zimmun is that the leader recites the **whole Birkat HaMazon** for everyone, including *"the land You gave our fathers."*
- After the Rambam's responsum, the **Ramban, Rashba, Rosh** and others followed **him**.
- The **Shulchan Aruch** (Orach Chaim 53) records that some disqualified a convert as chazan because he can't say "God of our fathers," and that **their view was rejected**.

That's also why a convert is called **בן אברהם / בת אברהם** (or **בת שרה**).

The **Ohr HaChaim** gives a different, Kabbalistic reason: converts' **souls were at Sinai**; they were lost and have come back. "Clearly not the Rambam's approach."

Letter 2: Is Your Spouse Decreed from Heaven?

Ovadia's teacher had told him that **everything is from Heaven, including whom you marry.** The Gemara (Sotah 2a): **forty days before conception a heavenly voice proclaims, "the daughter of so-and-so to so-and-so."** Today people say *"it's bashert."*

The Rambam utterly rejects it. You're right, and we have full free will; that's why there is reward and punishment.

- **הכל בידי שמים חוץ מיראת שמים**: Everything except fear of Heaven is in Heaven's hands, nature.

- He refers Ovadia to the **Eight Chapters** (studied together a year ago) and the **Mishneh Torah** (Hilchot Teshuvah, studied just now).

"Spiritual suicide"

Anyone who leaves the fundamentals and goes looking for one Midrash, one aggadah, or one statement of an early Gaon, and uses it to say "it can't be true," is committing philosophical suicide.

"Key lines to remember for life." The method is the reverse: **take the principles of the Torah, then fit the Midrashim around them.** "What people do is the opposite: the Midrash says this, so I'll build my whole world-view on this one Midrash and fit everything else in."

The proof from war

The Torah (Shofetim) exempts a man who has **betrothed a woman** and not yet married her from going to war, *lest he die and another marry her.* **If whom you marry is decreed, why worry?** The verse itself shows it isn't.

Letter 3: Is Islam Idolatry? And How to Treat a Convert

Ovadia's teacher had told him **Muslims are idolaters**; when Ovadia disagreed, the teacher **humiliated** him and called him a **fool**.

Islam is not avodah zarah

אלו הישמעאלים אינם עובדי עבודה זרה כלל... והם מייחדים לאל יתעלה ייחוד כראוי, ייחוד שאין בו דופי

These Ishmaelites are **not idolaters at all**... they affirm God's unity properly, a unity without flaw.

- **"They accuse us of saying God has a son"**, a false charge against some Jews. "Because they make false claims about us, are we going to make false claims about them? **We don't lie.**"
- **Praying where idols once stood?** Even if an idol were hidden in their sanctuary, their **hearts are directed to God**. The Gemara says someone who bows thinking he is bowing to Hashem, unaware of an idol before him, has done nothing wrong.
- **"Their other mistakes and stupidities I can't put in writing, for fear this letter will be picked up and I'll be informed upon."** One of them we saw in Hilchot Teshuvah: **the sensual paradise**.
- **Pagan origins.** Historically they had three deities and rites (named in the letter as Pe'or, Markulis and Kemosh), which they acknowledge: exposure, **throwing stones**, not wearing sewn garments. They still do these things. **But not for those purposes.** Some say they throw stones **to confuse the Satan**; their scholars say it is **to reject the idol**. "Whatever it is, it's just their practice. It's become tradition." Their hearts are to God.

Rabbeinu Tam said something similar about Christians

The tractate *Avodah Zarah* forbids trade with idolaters three days before their festivals. How, then, could Jews in Christian Europe trade at Christmas? **Rabbeinu Tam**: they do these things **as ancestral custom, not real belief**. "Unfortunately you could say that about many religions nowadays, and if we're honest and frank, our own as well."

Halachic upshot

The Gemara and Shulchan Aruch **forbid entering a church**, as a place of avodah zarah. **Based on this letter, entering a mosque is permitted**: they are pure monotheists. "They have many other problems, like the Rambam says, but this is not one of them."

"Was he drunk?"

Your teacher who embarrassed you and called you a fool **committed a terrible sin**; I hope by mistake. He must **ask your forgiveness** (even a teacher who embarrasses his student must), **fast, and cry out to Hashem**, and perhaps he'll be forgiven. **Was he drunk**, that he forgot the **36 places** the Torah commands us concerning the convert? **ולא תונו**: verbal abuse of a convert is a Torah prohibition.

- Even if he had been right, he should have explained gently. "All the more so when you're right and he's talking nonsense."

- **He was so busy worrying about whether Muslims are idolaters that he forgot the much bigger thing.**
- Parents we must **honour and fear**; prophets we must **heed**; it's possible to do those without loving them. **The convert we must *love***: **ואהבתם את הגר**, just as **ואהבת את ה' אלהיך**.

"It brought tears to my eyes"

A man who **left his father and his birthplace and a nation on the rise**, understood, and joined **this nation, despised today, subjugated to all the nations**; who recognised that ours is the religion of truth and righteousness, that other faiths have taken from it, added, subtracted, changed, lied, broken foundations, distorted; who pursued God, came under His wings, became a **student of Moshe**, and sought to be like an angel and cast this world from his heart; **you call such a man a fool?** God forbid!

You are not a fool. You are wise and understanding, walking a straight path, a student of Avraham, who left his family to follow God. He who blessed Avraham will bless you, in this world and the next. **May you yourself become a teacher and a posek**, and may all of Israel's consolations be yours.

"What really comes out in this letter is the love the Rambam had for Ovadia."

Summary

Letter	Ruling and teaching
1. Liturgy	A convert prays **exactly like every Jew**: "God of *our* fathers", "who chose *us*", "the land You gave *our* fathers", even "who took *us* out of Egypt". **Avraham is his father**; "you trace your lineage to Him who spoke and the world came to be." The Rambam chose the **Yerushalmi** over a stam Mishnah to reach it, and settled the debate against Rabbeinu Tam (Shulchan Aruch OC 53)
2. Free will	Marriage is **not** predetermined. Never build a world-view on one Midrash against the fundamentals. Proof: the betrothed man exempt from war
3. Islam and converts	Muslims are **pure monotheists**, not idolaters, despite pagan-origin rites (so a mosque may be entered). The teacher who shamed Ovadia sinned gravely; the convert must be **loved**

Coming Up

28 January and 4 February: the Rambam's **Letter on Astrology**, a longer letter, in two parts.

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